RPG EXCELLENCE

Decoding ISO 9001 2026

A practical guide to requirements evidence and quality decisions

First technical review edition October 2026

For business leaders, quality managers, process owners and internal auditors

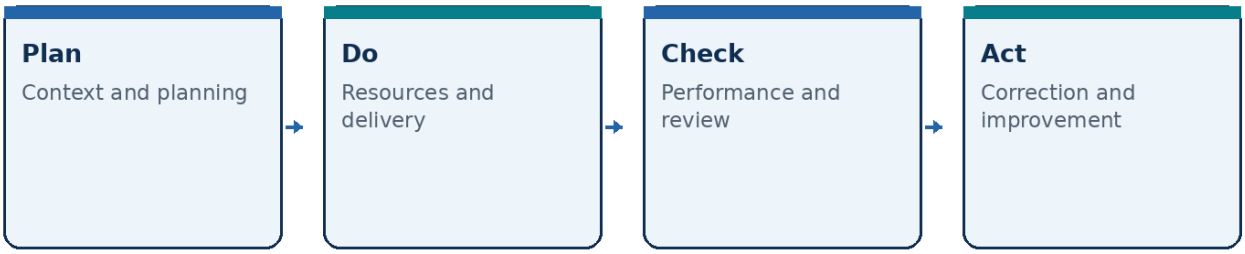
Read the requirement. Understand the decision. Test the evidence.

Original commentary and worked examples across every numbered clause, subclause and Annex A section in the supplied standard.

How to use this guide

A quality management system connects the customer promise with the people, processes and decisions needed to fulfil it. This book uses the RPG At a Glance approach: a requirement map, practical application, evidence, an auditor challenge and the management result. Detailed subclauses follow each overview.

The technical review uses the readable BS EN ISO 9001 2026 text supplied for this task, including clauses 1 to 10, Annex A and the bibliography. This independent RPG commentary does not reproduce the standard or imply ISO or BSI endorsement. Use the licensed standard for authoritative wording. All operational and numerical examples are hypothetical; suggested records and tools are examples, not extra requirements.



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Clauses 1 to 3 Foundations and vocabulary

1 Scope

The standard applies to organisations of any size and type seeking consistent fulfilment of customer and applicable legal requirements and enhanced satisfaction. QMS requirements complement output requirements. The standard scope, the organisation's QMS scope and its certification scope serve different purposes.

2 Normative references

ISO 9000 is an undated normative reference: the latest edition and amendments apply. A dated reference instead identifies a particular edition. The bibliography contains supporting literature; it does not make every listed document a certification requirement.

3 Terms and definitions

The following twenty three entries paraphrase the supplied vocabulary for practical use. ISO 9000 also applies. Read the terms alongside the operational requirements rather than using a dictionary definition alone to decide conformity.

3.1 The organisation being managed

Identify the entity or part of an entity with the functions, authority and relationships needed to achieve its objectives. In a group business, the QMS boundary determines which part is being discussed.

3.2 Interested parties

A party can affect a decision, experience its effects or perceive that it is affected. Relevance to the QMS is evaluated under 4.2.

3.3 Top management

Identify the people directing and controlling the entity at its highest relevant level. For a system covering only part of a larger business, this means the leadership of that part.

3.4 A management system

Policies, objectives, processes, structures and related practices operate together as a system. Several disciplines can share those arrangements.

3.4.1 The quality part of the system

The QMS is the part of overall management concerned with quality. It can share governance, resources and information with other disciplines.

3.5 Policy

A policy expresses the leadership's formal direction and intentions. It should guide decisions across the relevant work.

3.5.1 Quality policy

The quality policy gives direction specifically for quality and supports the setting of objectives. It should be coherent with broader organisational policy and can connect with vision and mission.

Clause 3 Vocabulary in practice

3.6 Objective

An objective specifies an intended result, which can exist at strategic, tactical or operational level. Separate the result from the activity chosen to achieve it.

3.6.1 Quality objective

A quality objective concerns a quality result. It normally draws on the quality policy and applies at relevant functions, levels and processes.

3.7 Risk

Risk describes what uncertainty does to the expected result; its effect can be positive or negative. Quality planning often focuses on harmful effects under 6.1.2, while opportunities receive their own treatment under 6.1.3.

3.8 Process

A process connects activities and inputs with a result, often using the output of another process. Its relationships matter as much as its individual steps.

3.9 Competence

Competence concerns applying knowledge and skills to achieve the intended result. Education, training and experience can contribute, but participation alone does not establish application.

3.10 Documented information

Controlled information can exist in any medium and come from different sources. It can support operation or record completed results.

3.11 Performance

Performance is a result that can be measured or evaluated, quantitatively or qualitatively. It can concern an activity, output, process or system.

3.12 Continual improvement

Improvement recurs over time to enhance performance. It can happen at intervals and through different types of change.

Clause 3 Conformity and assurance

3.13 Effectiveness

Effectiveness asks whether planned work happened and achieved the planned result. Completing a training session demonstrates delivery; showing that people can perform the required task tests its outcome.

3.14 Requirement

A requirement can be explicit, ordinarily implied or obligatory. Customers and other parties can generate requirements, and the organisation can set its own.

3.15 Conformity

Conformity concerns meeting an applicable requirement. Compare evidence with a defined criterion rather than an auditor's preference.

3.16 Nonconformity

A nonconformity is an unmet requirement. It is not every difference of opinion or every opportunity to work better.

3.17 Corrective action

Corrective action addresses causes to prevent the problem recurring. Correction deals with the detected instance.

3.18 Audit

An audit obtains evidence through a systematic, independent process and evaluates it objectively against criteria. Internal audits may use an external person acting for the organisation.

3.19 Measurement

Measurement establishes a value through a defined process. Explain what the value represents and how it was obtained.

3.20 Monitoring

Monitoring establishes status by checking, observing, supervising or reviewing. It may concern a system, process, activity or output at different stages.

Clause 4 Context of the organisation

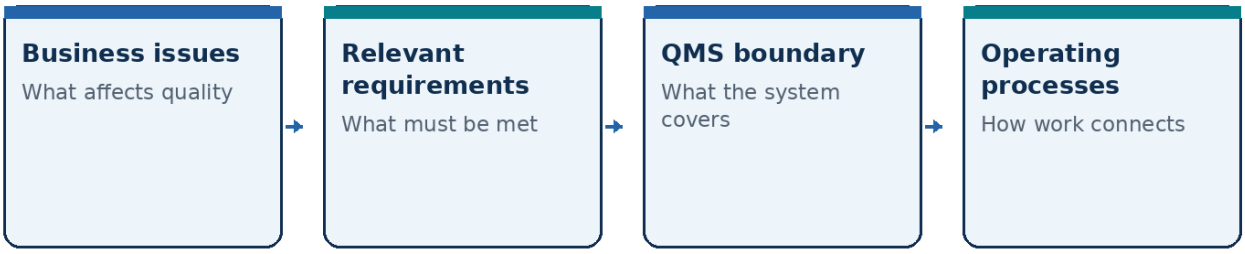
Define the business conditions, relevant requirements, scope and process relationships. These decisions should shape operations, not remain separate planning documents.

Requirement map 4.4 Process system.

Practical application Ask owners to trace one changed requirement into a process control.

Weakness to challenge A scope that obscures real design or outsourced responsibility.

Management output A documented scope and process architecture with clear operating criteria.



4.1 Business context

Identify the external and internal issues that matter to the organisation's purpose, direction and intended quality results. Decide explicitly whether climate change is relevant, then keep information about the issues under review. This clause does not require a SWOT document or make every sustainability topic a quality requirement. The important link is between the issue and the ability to achieve the QMS results.

Possible evidence Strategic reviews; context register; market and regulatory intelligence.

4.2 Interested parties and requirements

Identify relevant interested parties, determine their relevant requirements and decide which requirements the QMS will address. Monitor and review that information as expectations change. The selection is about relevance to the system; it does not mean accepting every preference of every stakeholder. Climate related requirements from a relevant party can matter even when the immediate operational effect is modest.

Possible evidence Interested-party register; customer and statutory requirements; contracts.

Clause 4 Detailed requirements 2

4.3 Scope and applicability

Set the QMS boundaries and applicability using context, interested party requirements and the products and services provided. Apply every requirement that is relevant within those boundaries. Document the scope, state the types of products and services covered and justify any requirement judged inapplicable. That judgement cannot undermine responsibility or capability for conformity and enhanced customer satisfaction.

Possible evidence Approved scope; site and process map; products and services.

4.4.1 Processes and interactions

Establish and operate the processes needed for the QMS, then maintain and improve them. Define inputs, expected outputs, interactions, operating criteria and evaluation methods, including relevant measures. Provide resources and assign responsibilities and authority. Address risks and opportunities, evaluate whether processes achieve their intended results and change or improve them when necessary. The clause concerns a connected system rather than a collection of isolated procedures.

Possible evidence Process architecture; SIPOC or flow maps; owners.

4.4.2 Information supporting processes

Make documented information available to the extent needed to support process operation and demonstrate that work follows the planned arrangements. The amount and form depend on what is necessary. A small process can have concise information, but it still needs enough instruction and evidence to support reliable work and a credible conclusion about implementation.

Possible evidence Current procedures and work controls; completed process records; retention controls.

Worked example

A hypothetical service team reviews twenty delayed jobs. Twelve began with missing customer information: 60 percent of the reviewed delays. Improve the acceptance handover and then compare a similar period. This sample describes delayed jobs, not the prevalence among all orders.

Takeaway A documented scope and process architecture with clear operating criteria.

Auditor challenge What changed in a real process when context or a requirement changed?

Clause 5 Leadership

Make leadership accountable for the results and for the conditions in which staff make quality decisions. Culture and ethical behaviour belong within leadership and awareness.

Requirement map 5.1 Leadership and commitment; 5.2 Quality policy.

Practical application Compare leadership decisions with employee accounts and operating evidence.

Weakness to challenge Commercial pressure that suppresses concerns or bypasses release authority.

Management output A useful policy, clear authority and resource decisions that support conformity.

5.1.1 Leadership and accountability

Top management is accountable for QMS effectiveness. Leaders establish policy and objectives compatible with strategy, integrate requirements into business processes, provide resources and communicate the importance of quality. They direct and support people, promote improvement and support other relevant leaders. Their responsibilities also include promoting quality culture, ethical behaviour, the process approach, risk based thinking and opportunity based thinking. Delegating work does not remove accountability for the result.

Possible evidence Leadership objectives; decisions; resource approvals.

5.1.2 Customer focus

Leadership must ensure customer and applicable legal requirements are identified, understood and consistently fulfilled. Determine and address the risks and opportunities affecting conformity and the ability to enhance customer satisfaction. Keep that customer focus active throughout the business. A favourable satisfaction survey does not excuse failure to meet a binding requirement.

Possible evidence Customer requirements and feedback; complaint trends; delivery and conformity data.

Clause 5 Detailed requirements 2

5.2.1 Policy commitments

Top management establishes a policy suited to the organisation's purpose, informed by context and supportive of strategy. It provides a basis for quality objectives and includes commitments to applicable requirements and QMS improvement. The policy can be concise, but its commitments need to guide priorities rather than remain disconnected from operational and commercial decisions.

Possible evidence Approved policy; leadership approval and review; strategic alignment.

5.2.2 Policy communication and application

Keep the policy available as controlled information, communicate it internally and make it available to interested parties where appropriate. People must understand, apply and implement it. Access to a poster or intranet page demonstrates availability; role specific decisions and conversations provide a better test of understanding and application.

Possible evidence Controlled publication; induction and briefing records; workforce interviews.

5.3 Responsibility and authority

Assign and communicate the responsibility and authority needed for relevant roles. Cover conformity of the QMS, reporting system performance and improvement opportunities, intended process results, customer focus and system integrity, including during change. These responsibilities can be spread across several roles. A particular job title or dedicated management representative is not prescribed.

Possible evidence Organisation charts; role profiles; process-owner mandates.

Worked example

Six of forty hypothetical orders await an inspection result. Fifteen percent of the release queue lacks planned evidence; this is not a defect rate. Leadership protects those orders, resources the review and communicates dates rather than treating the deadline as release authority.

Takeaway A useful policy, clear authority and resource decisions that support conformity.

Auditor challenge What did leadership decide when conformity conflicted with a deadline?

Clause 6 Planning

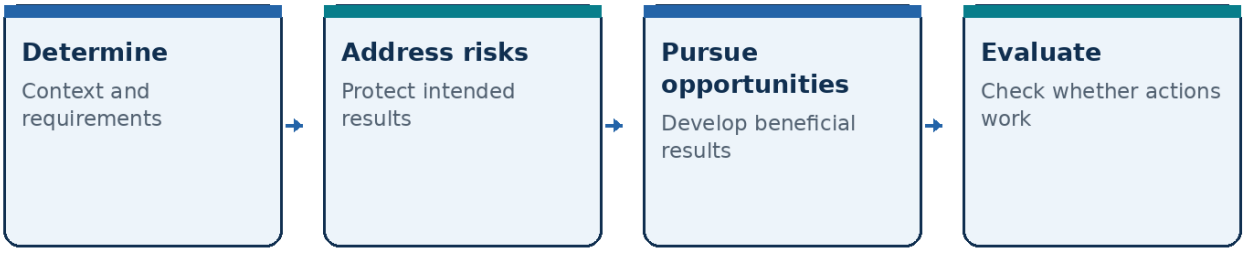
Separate the decision about risk from the decision about opportunity. Connect both with objectives and controlled change.

Requirement map 6.1 Risk and opportunity actions; 6.2 Quality objectives.

Practical application Sample one risk action, one opportunity and a recent change through to results.

Weakness to challenge Plans that name actions but never evaluate their effect.

Management output Prioritised actions, measurable objectives and changes whose results are reviewed.



6.1.1 Determine risks and opportunities

Use the issues from 4.1 and relevant requirements from 4.2 to identify the risks and opportunities that require attention. The purpose is to support intended system results, reduce unwelcome effects, strengthen beneficial effects and improve the system. This initial determination feeds the separate action decisions in 6.1.2 and 6.1.3; identifying an issue does not itself complete either action requirement.

6.1.2 Actions for risks

Determine, analyse and evaluate risks that could impair consistent conformity and enhanced customer satisfaction. Plan responses, integrate and implement them in QMS processes, and evaluate whether they work. The response must match the potential effect on intended results. Disruption is one possible source of risk. A named risk matrix or formal documented risk management procedure is not required by this clause.

Clause 6 Detailed requirements 2

6.1.3 Actions for opportunities

Determine, analyse and evaluate opportunities that could improve consistent conformity and customer satisfaction. Plan actions, incorporate them into QMS processes and evaluate their effectiveness. The actions must fit the organisation's context and support desired results. An opportunity is not automatically implemented because it sounds attractive; evaluation should establish what benefit is plausible and what the organisation can deliver.

6.2.1 Quality objectives

Establish quality objectives for relevant functions, levels and processes. Make them consistent with policy, measurable, informed by applicable requirements and relevant to conformity and customer satisfaction. Monitor, communicate and update them appropriately, and keep them available as documented information. Measurable need not mean a financial target or a percentage; the method must allow progress and achievement to be evaluated.

Possible evidence Objective register; baselines; targets.

6.2.2 Plans to achieve objectives

For each objective, determine the work to be done, resources, responsible people, completion timing and the way results will be evaluated. The organisation chooses the planning format. A target with no resources or delivery route is incomplete, even if its wording meets the objective criteria in 6.2.1.

Possible evidence Action plans; accountable owners; budgets.

6.3 Planned system changes

Carry out QMS changes through planned arrangements. Consider the purpose and potential consequences, system integrity, resources and information, and allocation of responsibilities and authority. Also consider communication, how effectiveness will be monitored and evaluated, and how results will be reviewed. Recovery plans and pilot tests can be useful methods, but the clause does not prescribe one universal change form or approval board.

Possible evidence Change requests; impact and risk reviews; approvals.

Worked example

In a hypothetical pilot, report corrections fall from 18 of 300 to 9 of 300. That is 6 percent to 3 percent: three percentage points lower, or a 50 percent relative reduction. Check comparable work and other changes before attributing the result to the pilot.

Takeaway Prioritised actions, measurable objectives and changes whose results are reviewed.

Auditor challenge What result demonstrates that the risk response or opportunity action worked?

Clause 7 Support

Provide the resources, people, knowledge and information needed for reliable work. Suitability and competence must be demonstrated in use.

Requirement map 7.1 Resources; 7.1.5 Monitoring and measurement resources; 7.5 Documented information; 7.5.3 Information control.

Practical application Compare task needs with available capability, current information and resource evidence.

Weakness to challenge Attendance presented as competence, or calibration status presented as suitability.

Management output Capable people and dependable resources supported by protected information.

7.1.1 Resources

Determine and supply the resources needed to establish, operate, maintain and improve the QMS. Consider both the capabilities and limitations of existing internal resources and what must come from external providers. Resource adequacy concerns the complete process, including review, correction and improvement, rather than only the visible delivery activity.

Possible evidence Resource plans and budgets; capacity reviews; constraints.

7.1.2 People

Determine and provide the people needed for effective QMS implementation and process operation and control. This is the people resource requirement. Competence is addressed separately in 7.2. In practice the two decisions interact: enough people without the necessary ability, or capable people without sufficient availability, can both leave the process inadequately supported.

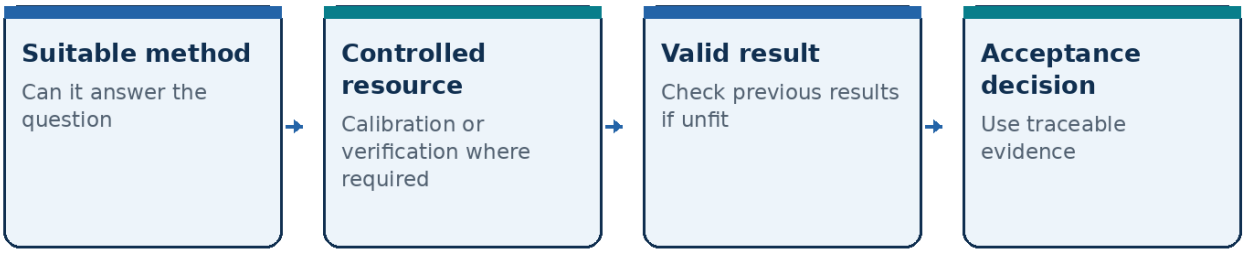
Possible evidence Workforce and competence plans; workload and capacity data; succession and deputy arrangements.

7.1.3 Infrastructure

Provide and maintain infrastructure needed for process operation and conforming outputs. Consider the resources relevant to the actual work, including premises, utilities, equipment, software, transport and communication technology. Infrastructure may support on site, remote or hybrid work. The necessary maintenance and availability arrangements depend on the process and its requirements.

Possible evidence Asset register; maintenance and availability data; capacity and resilience reviews.

Clause 7 Detailed requirements 2



7.1.4 Operating environment

Provide and maintain the operating environment needed for processes and conforming outputs. Relevant conditions may be physical, social or psychological, and differ between products and services. The examples in the explanatory note are contextual aids rather than a mandatory checklist of environmental measurements. Quality culture and ethical behaviour can influence these conditions.

Possible evidence Work-environment standards; surveys; observations.

7.1.5.1 Suitable monitoring and measurement

When monitoring or measurement verifies output conformity, provide resources capable of producing valid, reliable results. Ensure they suit the specific activity and remain fit for use. Keep appropriate documented evidence of suitability. This concerns more than equipment labels: methods, evaluation criteria and the people involved can influence whether the result is dependable.

Possible evidence Measurement-resource register; suitability rationale; maintenance.

7.1.5.2 Measurement traceability

When traceability is required or judged essential to confidence in results, calibrate or verify equipment, or do both, at appropriate specified intervals or before use. Use traceable reference standards; where none exist, document the basis adopted. Identify status and protect equipment from changes or damage that could invalidate results. If equipment is unsuitable, assess the effect on previous results and take necessary action.

Possible evidence Calibration certificates; traceability chain; status labels.

7.1.6 Organisational knowledge

Determine the knowledge needed to operate processes and achieve QMS results. Retain, apply and share it as necessary. When needs or trends change, assess existing knowledge and obtain or access additional knowledge and updates. A repository alone is insufficient if people cannot apply the knowledge when making the decisions it is intended to support.

Possible evidence Knowledge maps; lessons learned; technical standards.

Clause 7 Detailed requirements 3

7.2 Competence

Determine the competence needed by people whose work under the organisation's control affects QMS performance. Ensure competence using suitable education, training or experience. Where needed, act to acquire it and evaluate the effectiveness of those actions. Keep appropriate evidence of competence. The population can include contractors and other externally engaged people, not only employees.

Possible evidence Competence criteria and matrices; qualifications; observed assessments.

7.3 Awareness

Ensure people working under the organisation's control understand the policy, relevant quality objectives, their contribution to system effectiveness and the benefit of improved performance. They also need awareness of the consequences of failing system requirements and of the organisation's quality culture and ethical behaviour. A practical scenario can reveal whether this awareness influences decisions.

Possible evidence Induction and briefings; communications; interviews.

7.4 Communication

Determine the relevant internal and external communications: subject, timing, audience, method and responsibility. Decide these aspects according to the needs of the QMS. Confirmation of receipt or understanding is a useful control when warranted by consequence, but it is an implementation choice rather than an additional universal requirement in this clause.

Possible evidence Communication matrix; customer and regulator communications; escalation routes.

Clause 7 Detailed requirements 4

7.5.1 Necessary documented information

Include the documented information required by the standard and the information the organisation needs for an effective QMS. The appropriate extent depends on factors such as size, activities, complexity and competence. Do not confuse an optional document title with an optional requirement: a required piece of evidence still needs to be available even when it is held in a system rather than a standalone form.

Possible evidence Document architecture; mandatory and organisation-determined records; process-document matrix.

7.5.2 Creating and updating information

Identify and describe information appropriately when creating or updating it. Choose a suitable format and medium, and arrange review and approval for suitability and adequacy. Identification can use the organisation's own conventions. Review needs to check whether people can use the information correctly, not only whether its presentation follows a template.

Possible evidence Templates and metadata; authorship; review and approval trail.

7.5.3.1 Availability and protection

Control QMS information so it is available and suitable at the place and time of use. Protect it adequately against loss of confidentiality, misuse or loss of integrity. Availability and protection must work together: unrestricted access can undermine integrity, while excessive restriction can prevent competent people from obtaining the instructions they need.

Possible evidence Access controls; point-of-use sampling; change control.

7.5.3.2 Information lifecycle controls

Address distribution, access, retrieval and use; storage and legibility; change control; and retention and disposal, as applicable. Identify and control external information needed for QMS planning or operation. Protect evidence of conformity from unintended alteration. Viewing permission and editing authority are different decisions. Retained obsolete information must not become an uncontrolled operating instruction.

Possible evidence Access controls; point-of-use sampling; change control.

Worked example

Forty operators attend a hypothetical training session; thirty two pass the practical assessment. Attendance is 100 percent, but initially demonstrated competence is 80 percent. Provide supervised practice and reassessment before authorising independent work.

Takeaway Capable people and dependable resources supported by protected information.

Auditor challenge Can the person and resource perform the actual task, using current information?

Clause 8 Operation

Control the route from customer need to accepted product or service, including design, providers, release and exceptions.

Requirement map 8.2 Output requirements; 8.2.3 Requirement review; 8.3 Design and development; 8.4 External provision; 8.5 Production and service provision; 8.7 Nonconforming outputs.

Practical application Follow one normal order and one changed or failed order across the delivery route.

Weakness to challenge Requirements or evidence lost at a handover.

Management output Traceable requirements, controlled provision and authorised release.

8.1 Operational planning and control

Plan and control operational processes to meet output requirements and implement the actions from clause 6. Define requirements, process criteria, acceptance criteria and resources, then operate the controls. Keep enough documented evidence to establish planned operation and conformity. Control planned changes, assess consequences of unintended changes and mitigate adverse effects as needed. Bring relevant external provision within QMS control.

Possible evidence Operational plans; process criteria; work instructions.

8.2.1 Customer communication

Customer communications cover information about outputs, enquiries and contractual dealings including changes, feedback and complaints, and customer property. Provide relevant contingency information, including disruption affecting provision. Communication can be direct or through channels such as a website. Claims and messages need to remain consistent with what the organisation is capable of delivering.

Possible evidence Communication standards; quotations and contracts; customer portals.

Clause 8 Detailed requirements 2

8.2.2 Determine output requirements

Define requirements for the offered products and services, including applicable legal obligations and requirements the organisation considers necessary. Ensure the business can fulfil its claims about those outputs. A marketing statement can create an expectation that needs technical and operational support; checking only the signed purchase order may miss that commitment.

Possible evidence Requirement specifications; legal and regulatory inputs; claims review.

8.2.3.1 Review before commitment

Before committing, check capability against customer requirements, including relevant delivery and post delivery needs; known intended use needs not explicitly stated; internal requirements; legal obligations; and differences from earlier contract or order information. Resolve differences and confirm customer requirements when there is no documented statement. For internet sales, review of the applicable product information may be suitable instead of a separate formal review for every order.

Possible evidence Contract and order review; feasibility checks; approvals.

8.2.3.2 Evidence of review

Keep documented evidence of the review result and any new or changed requirements, as applicable. The record should identify what was decided and what information now governs delivery. A quotation marked approved does not necessarily show that a changed acceptance condition was considered or that the review outcome reached the next process.

Possible evidence Contract and order review; feasibility checks; approvals.

8.2.4 Changed requirements

When requirements change, update the relevant documented information and communicate it to the relevant interested parties. Consider internal work and external interfaces such as providers. Acceptance of the change is only part of the response; the updated requirement needs to reach the processes and people that must act on it.

Possible evidence Change requests; revised specifications and orders; impact reviews.

Clause 8 Detailed requirements 3

8.3.1 Design process

Establish, implement and maintain a design and development process appropriate to subsequent product or service provision. Determine applicability through the actual responsibilities within the QMS scope. Development can be iterative. The requirement does not insist on a single linear project method, but iteration does not remove the need for effective controls.

Possible evidence Design procedure; applicability decision; lifecycle model.

8.3.2 Design planning

Plan design stages and controls with regard to the work's nature, duration and complexity. Consider reviews, verification, validation, responsibility, authority, internal and external resources and interfaces. Consider involvement of customers and other relevant parties, subsequent delivery requirements and their expected level of control. Determine the documented evidence needed to demonstrate that development requirements are met.

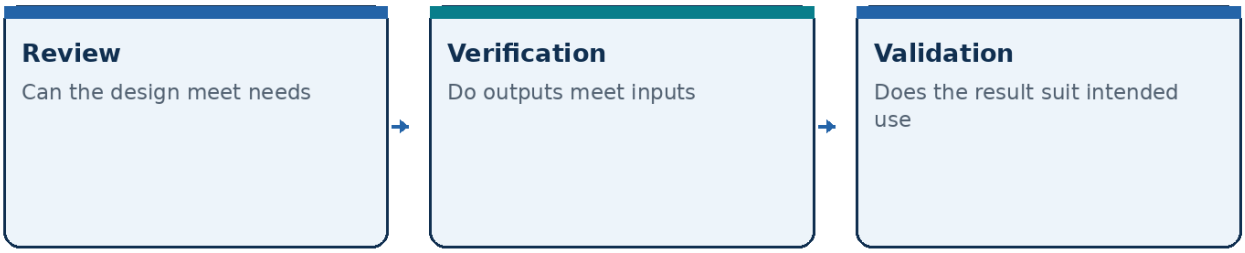
Possible evidence Design plan; stage gates; RACI.

8.3.3 Design inputs

Determine the essential development inputs, including functional and performance needs, learning from comparable work, legal requirements, committed standards or codes and consequences of failure. Inputs must be adequate, complete and clear; resolve conflicts. Keep evidence of inputs. Where information develops iteratively, update it coherently rather than using uncertainty as a reason to omit control.

Possible evidence Input specification; legal and standards review; lessons from prior designs.

Clause 8 Detailed requirements 4



8.3.4 Design controls

Define intended design results. Review ability to meet requirements, verify output against input and validate the resulting product or service against its intended application or use. Resolve problems found through these activities and keep evidence. Review, verification and validation serve different purposes even when a project combines them into one practical activity.

Possible evidence Review minutes; calculations; tests.

8.3.5 Design outputs

Ensure design outputs fulfil inputs and support subsequent processes. Include or refer to relevant monitoring and measurement needs and acceptance criteria. Define the characteristics and information essential to the intended purpose, including safe and proper provision. Keep evidence of outputs. Downstream teams need an executable specification rather than a technically interesting but incomplete design package.

Possible evidence Approved drawings/specifications; input-output traceability; acceptance criteria.

8.3.6 Design changes

Determine, review and control design changes during and after development so conformity is not adversely affected. Keep evidence of the change, review outcome, authorisation and any necessary measures preventing adverse effects. The review needs to consider the affected design and its use, rather than only the changed item in isolation.

Possible evidence Change requests; impact and risk review; verification/validation.

Clause 8 Detailed requirements 5

8.4.1 External provider control

Control external provision incorporated into the organisation's outputs, supplied directly to customers on its behalf, or used to perform part of a process. Apply criteria for provider evaluation, selection, performance monitoring and reevaluation based on capability to meet requirements. Keep evidence and necessary follow up actions. External provision must conform to requirements, not merely come from an approved name on a list.

Possible evidence Supplier segmentation; approval and selection; risk criteria.

8.4.2 Type and extent of control

Keep outsourced processes within QMS control. Define controls for the provider and for the resulting output. Consider the potential impact on customer and legal requirements and how effective the provider's own controls are. Determine verification or other necessary activities. Provider assurance and output acceptance are related decisions; a supplier certificate alone may not address the specific delivery risk.

Possible evidence Due diligence; audit and inspection plans; incoming verification.

8.4.3 Information for providers

Check requirements for adequacy before communicating them to providers. Communicate relevant output requirements, approval needs for outputs, methods, equipment and release, and competence or qualifications. Address interfaces with the organisation and relevant customers or other parties, performance controls and planned verification or validation at the provider's premises or another location. The appropriate detail depends on the supplied activity.

Possible evidence Purchase specifications; quality agreements; approved changes.

Clause 8 Detailed requirements 6

8.5.1 Controlled delivery conditions

Operate under controlled conditions, as applicable: suitable information defining output characteristics, activities and results; suitable monitoring and measurement; checks at relevant stages; suitable infrastructure and environment; and competent people. Validate and periodically revalidate processes when later monitoring or measurement cannot verify the resulting output. Include human error prevention and release, delivery and post delivery activities. Final inspection cannot substitute for a necessary process validation.

Possible evidence Work instructions; acceptance criteria; equipment and environment controls.

8.5.2 Identification and traceability

Identify outputs when needed for conformity and identify their monitoring and measurement status during provision. When traceability is required, control unique identification and keep the information needed to trace the output. A batch reference without a preserved connection to its processing and delivery history may identify the item while failing the required traceability purpose.

Possible evidence Identification and status controls; batch, serial or case records; personnel traceability where required.

8.5.3 Customer and provider property

Care for customer and provider property under the organisation's control or in use. Identify and verify it, protect and safeguard it, and report loss, damage or unsuitability to the relevant owner. Keep evidence of what occurred. Property can include premises, intellectual material and personal data, so the control is not limited to items booked into a stores system.

Possible evidence Property registers; receipt and condition checks; security and preservation.

Clause 8 Detailed requirements 7

8.5.4 Preservation

Preserve outputs during production and service provision to the extent needed for conformity. Consider applicable handling, storage, packaging, contamination prevention, transmission, transport and protection. This applies to tangible and intangible outputs. The chosen measures should preserve the characteristics that matter to acceptance, rather than simply demonstrate that a standard packing process was followed.

Possible evidence Preservation standards; environmental and shelf-life controls; handling records.

8.5.5 Post delivery responsibilities

Meet the post delivery requirements associated with the output. When deciding the necessary extent, consider legal obligations, possible unwanted consequences, the output's nature, use and intended life, customer requirements and feedback. Warranty, maintenance or disposal support may be relevant examples. The clause does not require every organisation to offer every kind of support service.

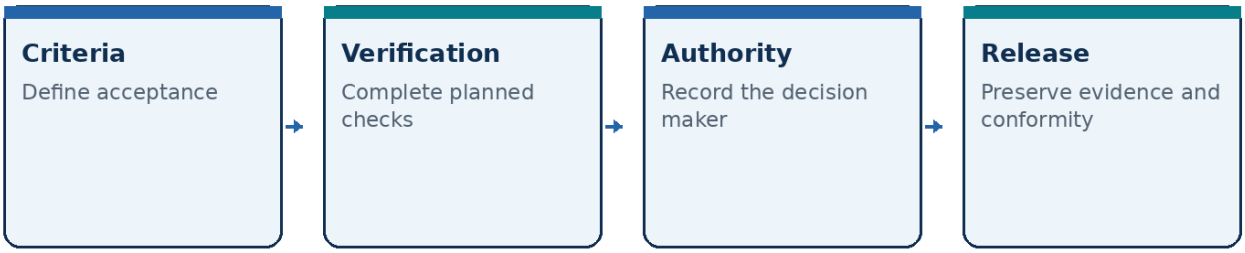
Possible evidence Warranty and support processes; service records; recalls.

8.5.6 Operational changes

Review and control production or service changes sufficiently to maintain conformity. Keep evidence of the review result, the people authorising the change and necessary follow up actions. This operating control complements wider QMS change planning in 6.3. The same change can engage both requirements without needing two unrelated bureaucratic processes.

Possible evidence Operational change log; risk and impact review; approvals.

Clause 8 Detailed requirements 8



8.6 Authorised release

Use planned checks at suitable stages to establish that output requirements are met. Normally complete the planned acceptance arrangements before customer release. Any exception needs approval by the relevant authority and the customer where applicable. Keep release evidence demonstrating acceptance conformity and identifying the authorising person. A known defect accepted under concession also needs the relevant control under 8.7.

Possible evidence Inspection and test results; service acceptance; release status.

8.7.1 Control nonconforming outputs

Identify and control nonconforming outputs to prevent unintended use or delivery. Respond according to the nature and effect of the failure, including failures found after delivery or during service. Possible responses include correction, containment or segregation, return or suspension, customer notification and authorised concession. Recheck conformity after correction. A suitable response can combine several measures.

Possible evidence Nonconformance record; identification and segregation; disposition.

8.7.2 Evidence of disposition

Keep evidence describing the nonconformity, actions, any concessions and the authority deciding the disposition. Connect the decision with the affected output so a reviewer can establish what happened and why. The record supports control of this output; deciding whether its cause needs wider corrective action is addressed in 10.2.

Possible evidence Description; affected output; containment.

Worked example

Forty hypothetical units need rework taking forty five minutes each at thirty pounds an hour. Direct rework labour is 40 times 0.75 times 30, or 900 pounds. This excludes scrap, materials and customer costs; it is not automatically the saving available from a proposed control.

Takeaway Traceable requirements, controlled provision and authorised release.

Auditor challenge Can one requirement be traced through review, delivery and release?

Clause 9 Performance evaluation

Use reliable evidence to evaluate performance and system effectiveness. Connect measures, audit conclusions and leadership decisions.

Requirement map 9.1 Monitoring measurement analysis and evaluation; 9.2 Internal audit; 9.3 Management review.

Practical application Check the raw sample behind a dashboard and follow a review decision into action.

Weakness to challenge Favourable averages or meeting records without a defensible conclusion.

Management output Valid analysis, objective audits and documented management decisions.

9.1.1 Methods timing and evaluation

Determine what to monitor or measure, the methods needed for valid results, when to perform the activities and when to analyse and evaluate the results. Evaluate QMS performance and effectiveness, and keep evidence of results. Data collection without a planned evaluation route can produce an extensive dashboard that gives management little reliable information about system effectiveness.

Possible evidence Measurement framework; KPI definitions; data-quality controls.

9.1.2 Customer satisfaction

Monitor customer satisfaction and determine how information will be obtained, monitored and reviewed. The organisation selects methods suitable to its customers and services. Complaints are one source, but their absence is not a complete satisfaction assessment. Review participation, relevance and competing signals when deciding what customer information supports a sound conclusion.

Possible evidence Satisfaction measures; complaints; retention and churn.

Clause 9 Detailed requirements 2

9.1.3 Analysis and evaluation

Analyse relevant monitoring and measurement information to evaluate output conformity, satisfaction, QMS performance and effectiveness, and whether planning was implemented effectively. Evaluate risk actions and opportunity actions separately, as well as provider performance and improvement needs. Presentation is not evaluation: the analysis needs to support a conclusion about these topics.

Possible evidence Integrated performance analysis; trend and variation review; supplier scorecards.

9.2.1 Internal audit purpose

Conduct internal audits at planned intervals to determine conformity with the organisation's own QMS requirements and the standard, and whether the system is effectively implemented and maintained. The organisation chooses intervals that suit the system. There is no universal annual audit frequency in this clause, and a document review alone may not establish operating effectiveness.

Possible evidence Audit reports; process and requirement trails; objective evidence.

9.2.2 Audit programme

Establish and operate audit programmes covering frequency, methods, responsibility, planning and reporting. Consider process importance, previous audit results and organisational changes. Set the objectives, criteria and scope of each audit, protect objectivity and impartiality, report to relevant managers and undertake correction and corrective action without undue delay. Keep evidence of programme implementation and audit results.

Possible evidence Programme risk rationale; schedules; plans.

Clause 9 Detailed requirements 3

9.3.1 Management review purpose

Top management reviews the QMS at planned intervals for continuing suitability, adequacy, effectiveness and strategic alignment. A review can be integrated into existing governance; the standard does not require a meeting with a particular title or a fixed yearly interval. Whatever format is used, leadership still needs to undertake the evaluation and demonstrate its results.

Possible evidence Review schedule; agenda; leadership participation.

9.3.2 Review inputs

Include previous review actions, changing context and changing relevant interested party needs. Review trends in nonconformities and corrective actions, monitoring and measurement, audits, satisfaction and relevant feedback, objectives, process and output conformity, and provider performance. Include improvement opportunities, resource adequacy and separate evaluations of risk and opportunity actions. A completed agenda is insufficient if one of these inputs was omitted from the evaluation.

Possible evidence Complete input pack; trends and comparisons; prior-action status.

9.3.3 Review decisions and evidence

Record review decisions about improvement opportunities, necessary QMS changes and resource needs. Keep documented evidence of the review results. Assigning owners, dates and follow up makes the decisions executable, but the exact tracker design is an implementation choice. A review may identify no need for a particular change; the evidence should still show that the relevant information was considered.

Possible evidence Minutes; decisions; action owners and dates.

Worked example

Twenty four of two hundred invited customers return a hypothetical survey; twenty one are satisfied. Respondent satisfaction is 87.5 percent and response is 12 percent. Do not describe 87.5 percent of all customers as satisfied on this evidence alone.

Takeaway Valid analysis, objective audits and documented management decisions.

Auditor challenge What decision follows from the evidence, and how was it acted upon?

Clause 10 Improvement

Improve the system and respond proportionately to nonconformities. Correction and cause removal are different decisions.

Requirement map 10.2 Nonconformity and corrective action.

Practical application Trace a problem from immediate control to the decision on cause and effectiveness.

Weakness to challenge Closing an action because a task was done without checking the intended result.

Management output Evidence of improvement and proportionate responses that address recurrence where needed.

10.1 Continual improvement

Improve the QMS's suitability, adequacy and effectiveness over time. Use monitoring, measurement, analysis, evaluation and management review to identify opportunities, then address them. Improvement includes processes, products and services, future needs and expectations, and correction, prevention or reduction of unwanted effects. Improvement can be incremental or involve larger change. This is the 2026 location of continual improvement; there is no 10.3 in the supplied edition.

Possible evidence Improvement portfolio; selection rationale; customer and process inputs.

10.2.1 Response and corrective action

React to a nonconformity and, where applicable, control and correct it and address its consequences. Evaluate whether cause removal is needed by reviewing the problem, determining causes and checking similar actual or possible problems elsewhere. Implement necessary action, review corrective action effectiveness and update risks, opportunities or the QMS if needed. Match the response to the effects. The clause does not demand a full 8D investigation for every problem.

Possible evidence Incident/finding; containment; correction.

10.2.2 Evidence of corrective action

Keep evidence of the nonconformity, subsequent actions and corrective action results. A useful case record connects the problem with the decision on cause removal, implementation and the effectiveness result. If proportionate evaluation concludes that further corrective action is unnecessary, record a defensible decision instead of implying that immediate correction alone always fulfils 10.2.

Possible evidence Finding record; evidence; action log.

Worked example

A hypothetical backlog starts at sixty cases. Twenty close, fifteen arrive and five reopen after failed effectiveness checks. The closing backlog is sixty, not fifty five. Administrative completion and verified improvement need separate visibility.

Takeaway Evidence of improvement and proportionate responses that address recurrence where needed.

Auditor challenge Was cause removal needed, and what establishes the effectiveness of the response?

Annex A Clarification 1

Annex A is informative: it clarifies interpretation without adding or changing requirements. It is not an implementation manual. The numbered notes below cover the complete supplied annex. RPG practical methods are commentary. The supplied 2026 edition has no Annex B.

A.1 Read clarification alongside the requirements

Annex A explains meaning and relationships without adding, removing or changing obligations. It is clarification rather than an implementation manual.

A.2 Use structure and wording accurately

Organise information for the people using it rather than copying the standard's sequence. A list's numbering identifies items; it does not automatically impose their order or priority. Appropriate concerns suitability and judgement; applicable concerns relevance and whether the requirement applies. Consider calls for thinking about a topic, whereas taking it into account includes it in the decision. Continual allows intervals; it does not mean uninterrupted activity. Ensure establishes accountability for the result and allows delegation of tasks. Availability concerns usable information; evidence concerns retained objective support. Strategy concerns coordinated decisions, plans and actions towards objectives.

A.3 Justify nonapplicability

An inapplicable requirement needs a reason tied to the organisation's context. The decision cannot impair output conformity, enhanced satisfaction or fulfilment of applicable legal obligations.

A.4 Context and the connected system

Read the following context explanations together. The business issues, stakeholder requirements, system boundary and process design influence one another.

A.4.1 Keep the context current

Issues affect purpose, direction and operating conditions, and change over time. Use their relevance to intended QMS results when deciding what matters.

A.4.2 Follow changing stakeholder requirements

Determine relevant parties and requirements, including provider requirements where external provision matters. Relevant climate expectations can arise through customers, obligations or commitments.

A.4.3 Explain activities and sites within the boundary

The scope can describe activities, products, services and related sites, including different site coverage where appropriate. Customers or the organisation's place within a larger entity can influence the boundary.

A.4.4 Evaluate processes as a system

Processes form a coherent QMS with defined inputs, outputs, responsibility and interactions. The process approach connects with PDCA and both risk and opportunity thinking.

Annex A Clarification 2

A.5 Leadership interpretation

The leadership clarification connects visible commitment with the way policy and assigned authority operate. Read the following topics alongside clause 5.

A.5.1 Make culture visible in decisions

Leadership involvement shows that quality matters. Culture, awareness, ethical decisions and customer focus reinforce confidence in meeting relevant requirements.

A.5.2 Connect policy and expectations

The policy can reflect the organisation's culture and ethical expectations in a way that fits its context. Understanding and application support consistent quality intent and objectives.

A.5.3 Keep responsibility clear when technology changes

Roles can share the responsibilities needed for system outcomes. Performance reporting and clear authority support integrity during change.

A.6 Planning interpretation

Planning clarification separates determination, risk response, opportunity response, objectives and change. These topics interact without becoming interchangeable.

A.6.1 Connect the three planning decisions

First identify the matters needing attention; then evaluate and implement the relevant risk or opportunity response. Read the following three explanations with that sequence of decisions in mind.

A.6.1.1 Distinguish exposure from beneficial circumstances

Risk concerns uncertainty and is often discussed as potential harm to QMS results. An opportunity arises from circumstances that could produce a benefit.

A.6.1.2 Apply risk thinking without prescribing a method

Risk thinking supports planned, controlled processes and dependable results during disruption. The annex does not impose a formal risk management methodology or a documented risk management process.

A.6.1.3 Recognise where opportunities arise

Context, interested parties, capacity, capability, competence and performance information can expose useful opportunities. Markets, technology or changed obligations may create beneficial circumstances.

A.6.2 Measure achievement in a suitable form

Quality objectives sit within broader organisational objectives and can operate at several levels. They can use quantitative or other suitable measurable forms.

A.6.3 Scale change planning to its effect

Change can arise internally, externally or through another management system and can bring risks or opportunities. Planning varies with the reason, complexity and significance of the change.

Annex A Clarification 3

A.7 Support interpretation

The support explanations connect resources, people, working conditions, knowledge and information with intended system results. They apply to modern as well as traditional working arrangements.

A.7.1 Resources and their interactions

Evaluate resources in relation to the processes they support. The following explanations show why adequacy cannot be judged from an asset list or headcount alone.

A.7.1.1 Evaluate the resource connection

Determine resources appropriate to intended results and consider their interactions with processes. An investment can remove one constraint while leaving another intact.

A.7.1.2 Include internal and external people

People supporting the QMS may be employees, contractors or temporary personnel. Technology supporting those roles can introduce opportunities and risks.

A.7.1.3 Consider remote and hybrid infrastructure

Infrastructure includes physical and software resources interacting with other processes. Maintenance, remote work, technology and relevant customer expectations can influence control, including interfaces with other management systems.

A.7.1.4 Understand conditions beyond direct control

Working conditions can affect conformity and customer perception and may change with technology or working practices. Where the organisation does not directly control the environment, complexity can increase.

A.7.1.5 Look beyond the instrument

Monitoring establishes status; measurement determines a value. Resources can include criteria, people and digital methods, as well as instruments.

A.7.1.6 Treat knowledge as changing capability

Knowledge must remain useful as context and experience evolve. Acquisition, application, updating and retention reduce the risk of loss or obsolescence.

A.7.2 Keep competence aligned with work

Competence applies to people affecting QMS performance under the organisation's control and may evolve with its context. It influences conformity and process risk.

A.7.3 Test awareness through ordinary decisions

Awareness connects role, authority and contribution to policy and objectives. People show it by recognising whether work meets requirements and responding appropriately when it does not.

A.7.4 Include automated communication

QMS communication can concern objectives, interfaces, resources, responsibility, risk, opportunity and feedback. It may occur between people or through automated device interactions.

A.7.5 Protect the information lifecycle

Information can have many formats and sources, including external origin. Controls support usability, availability and evidence of conformity.

Annex A Clarification 4

A.8 Operation interpretation

Operational clarification follows the route from planning and requirements through design, providers, delivery and release. The accountability for conforming output stays connected throughout that route.

A.8.1 Connect operational criteria with planning

Operation draws on planning and support. Criteria establish how process performance and output conformity are judged; resources enable the work.

A.8.2 Treat claims as part of the customer interface

Requirements can come from customers, obligations and the organisation itself. Communication helps establish the needs, capability, claims and relevant contingencies behind delivery.

A.8.3 Apply design control to services too

Development translates initial needs into defined characteristics, which may concern a service, physical product or a combination. Review, verification and validation answer distinct questions.

A.8.4 Keep outsourced accountability visible

External provision can include purchased outputs, associate organisations or interfaces outside the QMS scope. The organisation remains accountable for conformity and communicates relevant competence expectations.

A.8.5 Use controls that survive the whole delivery route

Process validation supports confidence where output checks cannot fully verify results. Identification and status show what an output is and whether checks are complete; traceability links its history where required.

A.8.6 Recognise release decisions at different stages

Confirmation of conformity may support movement to another stage as well as customer delivery. The relevant controls can concern delivery conditions too.

A.8.7 Expect failures at intermediate stages

A nonconforming output can arise within a process, at final delivery or through later feedback, even where a process appeared to operate as planned. Avoid limiting the register to returned goods.

Annex A Clarification 5

A.9 Performance evaluation interpretation

Evaluation connects information with conclusions about the system. The three following topics concern performance information, audit and leadership review.

A.9.1 Use customer perception in improvement

Monitoring and measurement supply information for analysis and evaluation. Methods can change with context, relevant requirements and strategy.

A.9.2 Audit all QMS processes through a sensible programme

Internal audit evaluates process status and contribution to system objectives across the QMS. Risk and context influence frequency and scope.

A.9.3 Bring all relevant audit trends to leadership

Management review uses evidence for decisions about the system, resources and improvement. Audit trends include first party, second party and third party QMS audits.

A.10 Improvement interpretation

Improvement concerns both beneficial development and the response to nonconformity. The two following explanations support proportionate decisions about system change and cause removal.

A.10.1 Improve as circumstances evolve

Changing context, knowledge, resources, data and technology can create improvement opportunities. The extent and nature of improvement may therefore change over time.

A.10.2 Evaluate the need for cause removal

Corrective action concerns both defective outputs and wider QMS nonconformities. The organisation chooses the investigation approach using context, recurrence risk, impact and relevant requirements.

Using the bibliography

The twenty six references support further reading. They are not twenty six additional certification obligations. Reference 2, ISO 9000, also has the normative role named in clause 2. Check the applicable edition and scope of an optional guide before using it.

Foundations and interpretation Bibliography references 1, 2, 3, 6 and 8.

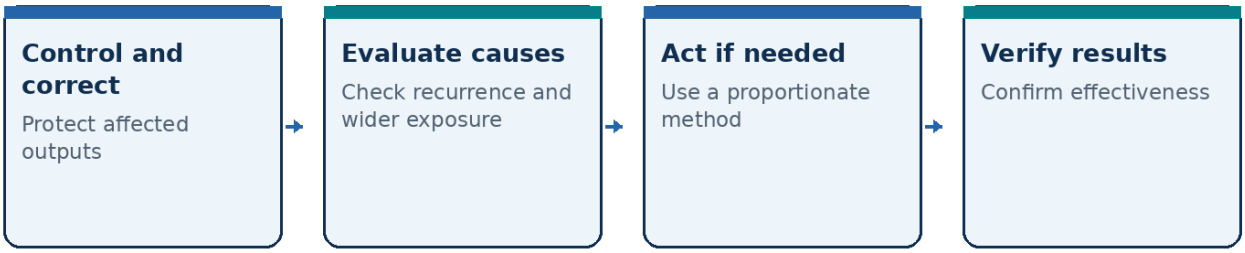
Audit and analysis Bibliography references 4, 5, 24, 25 and 26.

People and capability Bibliography references 9, 12, 14, 15 and 16.

Process controls Bibliography references 7, 10, 11, 13, 17, 18 and 21.

Customer experience Bibliography references 19, 20, 22 and 23.

Practical review tools and source record



A defensible finding

Identify the applicable requirement, describe the observed condition and cite the objective evidence. Distinguish an established failure from an issue needing more sampling. A preferred document, software package or method is not a requirement merely because an assessor likes it.

A proportionate corrective action

Control the immediate problem, evaluate the need for cause removal and the possibility of similar failures elsewhere, implement necessary action and review its effectiveness. Record decisions and results. Independent verification, 8D and a particular approval workflow can be useful RPG methods, but are not universal ISO 9001 obligations.

Read measures accurately

A rate needs a defined numerator, denominator, period and method. A change from 8 percent to 6 percent is two percentage points lower and a 25 percent relative reduction. Keep counts and exposure visible. An average readiness score cannot cancel an unmet requirement.

Source and technical review

Primary source: BS EN ISO 9001 2026 readable text supplied on 12 October 2026, covering clauses 1 to 10, Annex A and bibliography. Every numbered reference in those sections has been mapped to this guide. All twenty three vocabulary entries and all forty six numbered annex sections are included. Seven hypothetical numerical examples have been arithmetically checked.

Design reference: RPG Excellence ISO 9001 At a Glance files supplied in the website archive. The visual logic is retained; requirement statements are checked against the standard text. In particular, continual improvement is 10.1 and there is no 10.3. Website wording was not treated as the technical authority.

Public revision background: ISO standard page at https://committee.iso.org/standard/9001 and BSI revision briefing at https://www.bsigroup.com/en-GB/insights-and-media/insights/blogs/the-iso-9001-revision-a-new-era-for-quality-management/. Accessed 12 October 2026. A complete 2015 redline comparison and independent endorsement are not claimed.